THIS IS CHRISTOPHER: EXPLORING THE "SOUNDING SELF" THROUGH ELECTROACOUSTIC TREATMENT OF AN HISTORICAL AUDIO RECORDING

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ABSTRACT

In 2011 I created a fixed media electroacoustic piece, *This is Christopher,* based on a tape recording from the early 1980s. The recording was made by my grandmother and 2-year-old cousin Christopher as an "audio letter" to my family. In it, Nana told stories, chatted, and sang songs and nursery rhymes with Christopher. While listening to it I was struck by the many layers of significance in this historical audio document, in particular the process by which you can hear Christopher learning to speak and to express himself with sound and music. He listens, imitates, repeats, sings, improvises, and engages in verbal and musical play with Nana, including learning to say the phrase, "This is Christopher": the ultimate verbal declaration of self.

As one of the intended recipients of this "audio letter", turning it into a work of sonic art was an act with deep emotional significance for me. Not only was it a poignant record of a loving relationship between grandparent and grandchild, but also a personal tribute to family members. As would be expected, this informed the compositional process and treatment of the sound material. Furthermore, I've recently started teaching music to children in this age group, adding yet another layer of personal engagement.

In this talk I'll discuss the fascinating process of creating this piece. I'll focus on the compositional process, and also discuss technical issues and theoretical aspects, drawing on the work of Cathy Lane (2006).

This is Christopher (8:00) – awarded first equal in Waikato University Douglas Lilburn Composition Awards 2011.

REFERENCES

[1] Lane, C. "Voices from the Past: compositional approaches to using recorded speech," *Organised Sound,* 2006. *11*(1), pp 3–11.